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Faculty

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Notes By: - RAJESH KUMAR (Asst. Prof, EE Department)

UNIT-5

Communication Through Poems and Short Stories

Poems

'All the world's a stage'

(from As You Like It, spoken by Jaques)

By William Shakespeare

All the world's a stage,
And all the men and women merely players;
They have their exits and their entrances;
And one man in his time plays many parts,
His acts being seven ages. At first the infant,
Mewling and puking in the nurse's arms;
And then the whining school-boy, with his satchel
And shining morning face, creeping like snail
Unwillingly to school. And then the lover,
Sighing like furnace, with a woeful ballad
Made to his mistress' eyebrow. Then a soldier,
Full of strange oaths, and bearded like the pard,
Jealous in honour, sudden and quick in quarrel,
Seeking the bubble reputation
Even in the cannon's mouth. And then the justice,
In fair round belly with good capon lin'd,
With eyes severe and beard of formal cut,
Full of wise saws and modern instances;
And so he plays his part. The sixth age shifts

Into the lean and slipper'd pantaloon,
With spectacles on nose and pouch on side;
His youthful hose, well sav'd, a world too wide
For his shrunk shank; and his big manly voice,
Turning again toward childish treble, pipes
And whistles in his sound. Last scene of all,
That ends this strange eventful history,
Is second childishness and mere oblivion;
Sans teeth, sans eyes, sans taste, sans everything.

Short Questions & Answers:

a) What is the world compared to?

The world is compared to a drama stage.

b) “And they have their exits and their entrances” - What do the words ‘exits’ and ‘entrances’ mean?

The words ‘exits’ and ‘entrances’ mean birth and death.

c) What is the first stage of a human’s life?

The first stage of a human’s life is infant.

d) Describe the second stage of life as depicted by Shakespeare.

The second stage of a human’s life is a school boy. He slings his bag over his shoulder and creeps most reluctantly to school.

e) How does a man play a lover’s role?

A man plays a lover’s role by busily composing ballads for his beloved and he yearns for her attention.

f) Bring out the features of the fourth stage of a man as described by the poet. a)

In the fourth stage, a man is aggressive and ambitious and seeks reputation in all that he does. He promises solemnly to guard his country and becomes a soldier.

g) When does a man become a judge? How?

As he grows older, with maturity and wisdom, he becomes a fair judge. During this stage, he is firm and serious.

h) Which stage of man’s life is associated with the ‘shrunk shank’?

The sixth stage of man’s life is associated with the ‘shrunk shank’.

i) Why is the last stage called second childhood?

Slowly, the man loses his faculties of sight, hearing, smell and taste and exits from the roles of his life like a child.

Explain the following lines briefly with reference to the context. 3.

a) “*They have their exits and their entrances;*

And one man in his time plays many parts,”

Context : The above lines are taken from the poem “All the world’s a stage”, written by “William Shakeshpere”. It is an extract from Shakespeare’s play “As you like it”.

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Explanation: In a drama, every player enters the stage, acts his/her part and then exits. In the same way, We enter in this world by birth. We lead our life in different characters. We exit from this world at the time of our death.

Comment : Shakespeare's comparison of man's life with a drama stage is very apt.

**b) *“Jealous in honour, sudden and quick in quarrel,
Seeking the bubble reputation”.***

Context : The above lines are taken from the poem “All the world's a stage”, written by “William Shakeshpeare”. It is an extract from Shakespeare's play “As you like it”. According to the poet, every man has seven stages during his life time. These lines describe the fourth stage of a man's attitude.

Explanation: In his fourth stage, as a soldier, a man is very jealous in his honour. He is ready to fight with his enemy. He wants to gain the unstable fame and name even by sacrificing his life on the battlefield.

Comment : Shakespeare here shows the fourth stage man's attitude of yearning for reputation.

**c) *“Is second childishness and mere oblivion;
Sans teeth, sans eyes, sans taste, sans everything.”***

Context : The above lines are taken from the poem “All the world's a stage”, written by “William Shakeshpeare”. It is an extract from Shakespeare's play “As you like it”. According to the poet, every man has seven stages during his life time. These lines describe the last stage of a man's life.

Explanation: The last stage of a man is known as his second childhood. A child can not see, hear, smell and taste anything, during childhood. When a man grow old, slowly he loses his senses of sight, hearing, smell and taste like the child. So this stage of his life is considered as second childhood.

Comment : Shakespeare clearly expresses his views on the final stage of a man.

Long Questions & Answers:

a) Describe the various stages of a man's life picturised in the poem "All the World's a stage."

According to Shakespeare, the world is a stage and everyone is a player. He says that every man has seven stages during his life time. The first stage of a man is childhood. He plays in the arms of his mother. He often vomits and cries in this stage. In his second stage, the man is an unwilling school going student. He becomes a lover in his third stage. He is very busy composing ballads for his beloved and yearns for her attention. In the fourth stage, he is aggressive and ambitious. He seeks reputation in all what he does. He is ready to guard his country and becomes a soldier. In his fifth stage, he becomes a fair judge with maturity and wisdom. In the sixth stage, he is seen with loose pantaloons and spectacles. His manly voice changes into a childish treble. The last stage of all is his second childhood. Slowly, he loses his faculties of sight, hearing, smell and taste and exits from the roles of his life. Thus Shakespeare pictures the seven stages of a man's life in the poem 'All the World's a Stage'.

b) Shakespeare has skilfully brought out the parallels between the life of man and actors on stage. Elaborate this statement with reference to the poem.

Shakespeare considers the whole world a stage where men and women are only actors. In a drama, every player enters the stage, acts his/her part and then exits. In the same way, We enter in this world by birth. We lead our life in different characters. We exit from this world at the time of our death. Shakespeare says that every man has seven stages during his life time. In a drama, a player loves his beloved for the sake of the play. At the end, the players say goodbyes and part away. In real life, husband and wife lead their life till death knocks at their door. Like the drama's end, death parts them. The players in the drama really wants the reputation for their performance. For fame and name, they give their best on the stage. A man in the fourth stage also is an aggressive and ambitious. He seeks reputation in all what he does, like the player in the drama. Thus Shakespeare has skilfully brought out the parallels between the life of man and actors on stage.

A Psalm of Life

By Henry Wadsworth Longfellow

Tell me not, in mournful numbers,
Life is but an empty dream!
For the soul is dead that slumbers,
And things are not what they seem.

Life is real! Life is earnest!
And the grave is not its goal;
Dust thou art, to dust returnest,
Was not spoken of the soul.

Not enjoyment, and not sorrow,
Is our destined end or way;
But to act, that each to-morrow
Find us farther than to-day.

Art is long, and Time is fleeting,
And our hearts, though stout and brave,
Still, like muffled drums, are beating
Funeral marches to the grave.

In the world's broad field of battle,
In the bivouac of Life,
Be not like dumb, driven cattle!
Be a hero in the strife!

Trust no Future, howe'er pleasant!
Let the dead Past bury its dead!
Act,— act in the living Present!
Heart within, and God o'erhead!

Lives of great men all remind us
We can make our lives sublime,
And, departing, leave behind us
Footprints on the sands of time;

Footprints, that perhaps another,
Sailing o'er life's solemn main,
A forlorn and shipwrecked brother,
Seeing, shall take heart again.

Let us, then, be up and doing,
With a heart for any fate;
Still achieving, still pursuing,
Learn to labor and to wait.

Short Questions & Answers:

i) Why should we not trust the future?

Answer : We should not trust the future even though it may seem pleasant because the future is never fixed. We never know what we might face in our future. So, the poet says that it's better to live in the present because the present is in our hands.

ii) How should we treat our past? Why?

Answer : We should bury our past completely, like we bury dead people who cannot return to our present and future. This is necessary because if we bear our past along with us, we will never be able to progress in the present and future. The past is dead and useless.

iii) How does the poet ask us about the 'Present'?

Answer : The poet asks us to act courageously in the present and never lose faith in God. He says that people should bury their pasts and move on in life with new vigour and freshness. Our present is a beautiful gift and we should not ruin it by thinking about the past.

iv) What is the secret to success?

Answer : The secret of success is that we should let go of our past, live and act in the present and never trust our future however pleasant it might be. We should place our faith completely in God and continue to strive effortlessly. A wise man makes his present strong and bright by working day and night without rest and having firm faith in the justice of God.

v) What role does God play in a person's life? What should man do?

Answer : God plays the most important role in a person's life. He makes one work towards success even if there are obstacles in one's path. Man should place his faith wholeheartedly in God. Only then will he be able to confidently work and achieve great heights.

Question 2 : Read the extract given below and answer the questions that follow.

"Not enjoyment, and not sorrow,

Is our destined end or way;

But to act, that each tomorrow

Find us farther than today."

i) Explain the line, "Is our destined end or way".

Answer : In this line, the poet says enjoyment or sorrow are not the destined end or way of living. Our lives should not be based just on enjoyment or mourning. Instead, our aim in life should be to act wisely each day so that we can create a better future.

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ii) What is important to us when we are born in this world?

Answer : When we are born in this world, it is important to us that we should complete the task assigned to us by our creator and instead of shirking work, we should continue working in a way that we might make steady progress.

iii) How is enjoyment and sorrow not our destined 'end' or 'way'?

Answer : Enjoyment and sorrow are not our destined end or way because our lives are not just based on how we enjoy things or how much sad we are. Instead, the more purposeful thing in life is to act wise and create a good future. The real aim of life is to advance, to go higher in every field of life and to make glorious events.

iv) Name the poem and the poet. What should a person do according to the poet?

Answer : The name of the poem is 'A Psalm of Life'. The name of the poet is 'Henry Wadsworth Longfellow'. A person should not let his life be dictated by how much joy or sorrow he feels, but instead he must strive towards perfection and make his future better. The real value of life lies in the labour that we put in everyday for a better future.

v) How should our future be? What can we do to brighten it?

Answer : Our future should be wise and bright without the governance of enjoyment and sorrow. In order to brighten it, we should continue to achieve great heights and strive towards perfection. We should act wisely so that our tomorrow is better than our today. We should engage ourselves in thoughts and actions of high seriousness. We must try to make improvements and achievements to justify our existence as human beings.

Question 4 : Read the extract given below and answer the questions that follow.

"Life is real! life is earnest!

And the grave is not its goal;

Dust thou art, to dust thou returnest,

Was not spoken of the soul."

i) Explain the line, "Life is real! Life is earnest!"

Answer : In this line, the poet wants to say that life is real and serious. It should not be treated lightly. Death is not life's goal and life does not end with death. With death, only our body ends and not our soul. So, we should always engage in work that creates our memory in the world.

ii) What are poet's views on 'life'?

Answer : The poet believes that life is serious and real gift nature has bestowed on us. We should not spend it in procrastination. We should not wait for death to overcome us. Instead, we should do things which make our lives memorable.

iii) Do you agree with the poet that the grave is not the goal of life? Why?

Answer : Yes, Death is not the ultimate goal of life. Our aim in life should be to make it most beautiful before death arrives. We should do things in life which make our future better and create a happy environment for everyone.

iv) How should one lead his life?

Answer : One should lead one's life with seriousness and not take it lightly. Death is not the ultimate goal of life. Our aim in life should be to make it most beautiful before death arrives. We should do things in life which make our future better and create a happy environment for everyone.

v) Do you agree with what the poet says? Why?

Answer : Yes, the poet is right in saying that life is a very precious gift and we must make the most out of it. The poet says that life is not made to embrace death ultimately. Instead, it is made to fulfil one's aspirations, tasks and responsibilities on our way to death. It is the body which dies, not the soul. We should consider life as a journey of achievement and find fulfillment in action.

Long Questions & Answers:

Question 1 : Why does the poet prefer ...The 'past' is dead, a part of history.

Answer: It is not going to come back, nor basking in past glory can get us the benefit in the present. Pining over sorrowful things already consigned to history only dampens our spirit. In the same breath, 'Future' is uncertain, illusory, and deceptive. Banking on future only robs us of initiative to face the rough and grind of life. Thinking these, the author asks his readers to focus on the present, and do everything with the best of efforts. He asks us to treat God as the guide when we grapple with the tasks of the present.

Question 2 : What does the poet say about his past life and gives a message to all audiences?

Answer: when he was devastated with grief after the death of his wife. However, he drew solace and strength from the Bible, and pulled himself up to face life.

The author implores his readers to shake off despondency, lethargy, and frustration that dot each of our lives at different times. He says that the best antidote to such misery is to take the sorrows and failures of life in one's stride, and forge ahead with renewed vigour, so that the accomplishments of tomorrow outshine those of today. It means leaping to greater and greater heights in one's creative endeavours.

Question 3 : What attitude does the poet challenge and What is the poet's observation?

Answer: The poet gives a clarion call for action, effort, and utilization of all the creative instincts bestowed upon us by God. He has asked human beings to keep away from defeatist thoughts, happy-go-lucky attitude, and laziness. In many ways, such values are also taught to us by the Bhagbat Gita, which says that doing one's duty sincerely is the greatest service to God. Life should be treated as an opportunity the mental faculties to their best extent. Slipping back to inaction due to one failure anywhere is a vice, never to be resorted to by anyone.

The soul is the core of life. It imparts the driving force needed for action, confronting failures, striving anew, and creating something great. Soul is anathema to laxity, excuses, inaction and laziness.

Short Stories

The Three Questions

by Leo Tolstoy

It once occurred to a certain king, that if he always knew the right time to begin everything; if he knew who were the right people to listen to, and whom to avoid, and, above all, if he always knew what was the most important thing to do, he would never fail in anything he might undertake.

And this thought having occurred to him, he had it proclaimed throughout his kingdom that he would give a great reward to any one who would teach him what was the right time for every action, and who were the most necessary people, and how he might know what was the most important thing to do.

And learned men came to the King, but they all answered his questions differently.

In reply to the first question, some said that to know the right time for every action, one must draw up in advance, a table of days, months and years, and must live strictly according to it. Only thus, said they, could everything be done at its proper time. Others declared that it was impossible to decide beforehand the right time for every action; but that, not letting oneself be absorbed in idle pastimes, one should always attend to all that was going on, and then do what was most needful. Others, again, said that however attentive the King might be to what was going on, it was impossible for one man to decide correctly the right time for every action, but that he should have a Council of Wise Men, who would help him to fix the proper time for everything.

But then again others said there were some things which could not wait to be laid before a Council, but about which one had at once to decide whether to undertake them or not. But in order to decide that, one must know beforehand what was going to happen. It is only magicians who know that; and, therefore, in order to know the right time for every action, one must consult magicians.

Equally various were the answers to the second question. Some said, the people the King most needed were his councilors; others, the priests; others, the doctors; while some said the warriors were the most necessary.

To the third question, as to what was the most important occupation: some replied that the most important thing in the world was science. Others said it was skill in warfare; and others, again, that it was religious worship. All the answers being different, the King agreed with none of them, and gave the reward to none. But still wishing to find the right answers to his questions, he decided to consult a hermit, widely renowned for his wisdom.

The hermit lived in a wood which he never quitted, and he received none but common folk. So the King put on simple clothes, and before reaching the hermit's cell dismounted from his horse, and, leaving his bodyguard behind, went on alone. When the King approached, the hermit was digging the ground in front of his hut. Seeing the King, he greeted him and went on digging. The hermit was frail and weak, and each time he stuck his spade into the ground and turned a little earth, he breathed heavily.

The King went up to him and said: "I have come to you, wise hermit, to ask you to answer three questions: How can I learn to do the right thing at the right time? Who are the people I most need, and to whom should I, therefore, pay more attention than to the rest? And, what affairs are the most important

and need my first attention?"

The hermit listened to the King, but answered nothing. He just spat on his hand and recommenced digging. "You are tired," said the King, "let me take the spade and work awhile for you."

"Thanks!" said the hermit, and, giving the spade to the King, he sat down on the ground.

When he had dug two beds, the King stopped and repeated his questions. The hermit again gave no answer, but rose, stretched out his hand for the spade, and said, "Now rest awhile--and let me work a bit." But the King did not give him the spade, and continued to dig. One hour passed, and another. The sun began to sink behind the trees, and the King at last stuck the spade into the ground, and said, "I came to you, wise man, for an answer to my questions. If you can give me none, tell me so, and I will return home."

"Here comes some one running," said the hermit, "let us see who it is."

The King turned round, and saw a bearded man come running out of the wood. The man held his hands pressed against his stomach, and blood was flowing from under them. When he reached the King, he fell fainting on the ground moaning feebly. The King and the hermit unfastened the man's clothing. There was a large wound in his stomach. The King washed it as best he could, and bandaged it with his handkerchief and with a towel the hermit had. Again and again the King washed and rebandaged the wound. At last the man revived and asked for something to drink. The King brought fresh water and gave it to him. Meanwhile the sun had set, and it had become cool. So the King, with the hermit's help, carried the wounded man into the hut and laid him on the bed. Lying on the bed the man closed his eyes and was quiet; but the King was so tired with his walk and with the work he had done, that he crouched down on the threshold, and also fell asleep--so soundly that he slept all through the short summer night.

When he awoke in the morning, it was long before he could remember where he was, or who was the strange bearded man lying on the bed and gazing intently at him with shining eyes.

"Forgive me!" said the bearded man in a weak voice, when he saw that the King was awake and was looking at him. "I do not know you, and have nothing to forgive you for," said the King.

"You do not know me, but I know you. I am that enemy of yours who swore to revenge himself on you, because you executed his brother and seized his property. I knew you had gone alone to see the hermit, and I resolved to kill you on your way back. But the day passed and you did not return. So I came out from my ambush to find you, and I came upon your bodyguard, and they recognized me, and wounded me. I escaped from them, but should have bled to death had you not dressed my wound. I wished to kill you, and you have saved my life. Now, if I live, and if you wish it, I will serve you as your most faithful slave, and will bid my sons do the same. Forgive me!"

The King was very glad to have made peace with his enemy so easily, and to have gained him for a friend, and he not only forgave him, but said he would send his servants and his own physician to attend him, and promised to restore his property.

Having taken leave of the wounded man, the King went out into the porch and looked around for the hermit. Beforegoing away he wished once more to beg an answer to the questions he had put. The hermit was outside, on his knees, sowing seeds in the beds that had been dug the day before.

The King approached him, and said, "For the last time, I pray you to answer my questions, wise man."

"You have already been answered!" said the hermit still crouching on his thin legs, and looking up at the King, who stood before him.

"How answered? What do you mean?" asked the King.

"Do you not see," replied the hermit. "If you had not pitied my weakness yesterday, and had not dug these beds for me, but had gone your way, that man would have attacked you, and you would have repented of not having stayed with me. So the most important time was when you were digging the beds; and I was the most important man; and to do me good was your most important business. Afterwards, when that man ran to us, the most important time was when you were attending to him, for if you had not bound up his wounds he would have died without having made peace with you. So he was the most important man, and what you did for him was your most important business.

Remember then: there is only one time that is important -- and that is now! It is the most important time because it is the only time when we have any power.

The most necessary man is he with whom you are, for no man knows whether he will ever have dealings with anyone else.

And the most important thing to do is, to do good, because for that purpose alone was man sent into this life!"

Short Questions & Answers:

Question 1. Why did the king send two messengers throughout his kingdom?

Answer: The king sent his messengers throughout his kingdom to look for wise people.

Question 2. How did the king promise to reward the person who would answer his questions correctly?

Answer: The king promised to reward the person with a huge sum of money. If anyone gave suitable answer to his question.

Question 3. Where did the king find place?

Answer: The king finally found solace by seeking the hermits advice who lived in a distant jungle.

Question 4. Where did the hermit live?

Answer: The hermit lived in the forest

Question 5. Why did the king refuse to give reward to anyone?

Answer: The king was not satisfied with the answers of the wise men. They all had given different answers to the same questions because of which he was unable to come to a conclusion, so he refused giving the reward to anyone.

Question 6. What had compelled the king to leave his guards and horse?

Answer: The king knew that the hermit meet only ordinary man so left behind his horse and bodyguards and went to meet the hermit in his hut in the woods all alone.

Question 7. What do you gathered about the wise hermit from the lesson?

Answer: The hermit was a weak old man and used to live amidst the woods which he would never leave. He was digging the ground in front of his hut for sowing seeds when king arrived and the tedious task had made him tired.

Question 8. Who was the intruder? What made him visit the hermit?

Answer: The intruder was enemy of the king he had planned to attack the king but was instead attacked by the king's bodyguards, as they had recognized him. He had received a wound in his stomach. He was rushing towards the hermit's hut for help.

Long Questions & Answers:

Question 1. What were the replies the king received for his first question?

Answer: In reply to his first question, the king was advised to follow a timetable by some men. There were some people who were of the opinion that it was impossible to decide the right time in advance. The king was suggested to keep a note of all happenings around him, avoid indulging in excessive pleasure and do everything that seemed important at any particular time. Along with this he should have a team of intelligent people to guide to him to the right thing at the right time.

Question 2. King has right sense of judgement. Do you agree or not? Give examples in support of your answer.

Answer: The king wanted to be a good ruler and has a fair sense of judgement. He was seeking answers for the three questions which he thought would help him in his mission. The king was kindhearted, when he found the old man tired of digging the ground, he offered him his help. He kept on bandaging the bearded man's wound until blood stopped coming out from it. He was down to earth, he dressed up like a common man spent the night sleeping on floor at the hermit hut. He forgave the wrong and promised to help him in every possible way.

Question 3. The king is the main character of the story. Explain giving three examples.

Answer: The whole story revolves around the king. The king had known the hermit's nature of meeting only ordinary men. So, he gave up his king's attire, left behind his soldiers and the horse and went alone to meet him. He offered the hermit his help in digging the ground. He did this till evening. This helped him avoid the attack planned by the bearded man. He helped the bearded man bandaging his wound and offered him water. He saved his life. This helped him made friends with his enemy.

Question 4. Do you think we should help people in need? Why so?

Answer: We should always help people in need. We have been sent to this world to do good to others. If we are good and kind towards other, people will respect us for our kindness. Being kind and helpful keeps us happy from within. We feel happiness when we bring smile on the face of others. We earn their good wishes and blessings in return; It makes us a good human being. To help others is the greatest motto of humanity and we should adhere to it. The king is an embodiment of humanity and kindness. What more can be learnt from him.

Question 5. The king helped the hermit digging the beds. He even slept on the floor of the hut and lived like a simple man in the hermit hut. What lesson we learnt from this?

Answer: The king wasn't carried away with immature suggestions of his courtiers. The king found the old hermit tried digging the beds so he offered his help to the man. He was accustomed of comfort and lavishness in his palace still at hermit's home he slept on the floor. At our homes we get all the luxuries but if one day there comes a situation where we have to live without them we should be prepared for that. At the end, we must say that he was an embodiment of intellect humility and decisive in true sense.

The Necklace

By Guy de Maupassant

She was one of those pretty and charming girls born, as if by an error of fate, into a family of clerks. She had no dowry, no expectations, no means of becoming known, understood, loved or wedded by a man of wealth and distinction; and so she let herself be married to a minor official at the Ministry of Education.

She dressed plainly because she had never been able to afford anything better, but she was as unhappy as if she had once been wealthy. Women don't belong to a caste or class; their beauty, grace, and natural charm take the place of birth and family. Natural delicacy, instinctive elegance and a quick wit determine their place in society, and make the daughters of commoners the equals of the very finest ladies.

She suffered endlessly, feeling she was entitled to all the delicacies and luxuries of life. She suffered because of the poorness of her house as she looked at the dirty walls, the worn-out chairs and the ugly curtains. All these things that another woman of her class would not even have noticed, tormented her and made her resentful. The sight of the little Brenton girl who did her housework filled her with terrible regrets and hopeless fantasies. She dreamed of silent antechambers hung with Oriental tapestries, lit from above by torches in bronze holders, while two tall footmen in knee-length breeches napped in huge armchairs, sleepy from the stove's oppressive warmth. She dreamed of vast living rooms furnished in rare old silks, elegant furniture loaded with priceless ornaments, and inviting smaller rooms, perfumed, made for afternoon chats with close friends - famous, sought after men, who all women envy and desire.

When she sat down to dinner at a round table covered with a three-day-old cloth opposite her husband who, lifting the lid off the soup, shouted excitedly, "Ah! Beef stew! What could be better," she dreamed of fine dinners, of shining silverware, of tapestries which peopled the walls with figures from another time and strange birds in fairy forests; she dreamed of delicious dishes served on wonderful plates, of whispered gallantries listened to with an inscrutable smile as one ate the pink flesh of a trout or the wings of a quail.

She had no dresses, no jewels, nothing; and these were the only things she loved. She felt she was made for them alone. She wanted so much to charm, to be envied, to be desired and sought after.

She had a rich friend, a former schoolmate at the convent, whom she no longer wanted to visit because she suffered so much when she came home. For whole days afterwards she would weep with sorrow, regret, despair and misery.

One evening her husband came home with an air of triumph, holding a large envelope in his hand.

"Look," he said, "here's something for you."

She tore open the paper and drew out a card, on which was printed the words:

"The Minister of Education and Mme. Georges Rampouneau request the pleasure of M. and Mme. Loisel's company at the Ministry, on the evening of Monday January 18th."

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Instead of being delighted, as her husband had hoped, she threw the invitation on the table resentfully, and muttered:

"What do you want me to do with that?"

"But, my dear, I thought you would be pleased. You never go out, and it will be such a lovely occasion! I had awful trouble getting it. Every one wants to go; it is very exclusive, and they're not giving many invitations to clerks. The whole ministry will be there."

She stared at him angrily, and said, impatiently:

"And what do you expect me to wear if I go?"

He hadn't thought of that. He stammered:

"Why, the dress you go to the theatre in. It seems very nice to me ..."

He stopped, stunned, distressed to see his wife crying. Two large tears ran slowly from the corners of her eyes towards the corners of her mouth. He stuttered:

"What's the matter? What's the matter?"

With great effort she overcame her grief and replied in a calm voice, as she wiped her wet cheeks:

"Nothing. Only I have no dress and so I can't go to this party. Give your invitation to a friend whose wife has better clothes than I do."

He was distraught, but tried again:

"Let's see, Mathilde. How much would a suitable dress cost, one which you could use again on other occasions, something very simple?"

She thought for a moment, computing the cost, and also wondering what amount she could ask for without an immediate refusal and an alarmed exclamation from the thrifty clerk.

At last she answered hesitantly:

"I don't know exactly, but I think I could do it with four hundred *francs*."

He turned a little pale, because he had been saving that exact amount to buy a gun and treat himself to a hunting trip the following summer, in the country near Nanterre, with a few friends who went lark-shooting there on Sundays.

However, he said:

"Very well, I can give you four hundred *francs*. But try and get a really beautiful dress."

The day of the party drew near, and Madame Loisel seemed sad, restless, anxious. Her dress was ready, however. One evening her husband said to her:

"What's the matter? You've been acting strange these last three days."

She replied: "I'm upset that I have no jewels, not a single stone to wear. I will look cheap. I would almost rather not go to the party."

"You could wear flowers," he said, "They are very fashionable at this time of year. For ten *francs* you could get two or three magnificent roses."

She was not convinced.

"No; there is nothing more humiliating than looking poor in the middle of a lot of rich women."

"How stupid you are!" her husband cried. "Go and see your friend Madame Forestier and ask her to lend you some jewels. You know her well enough for that."

She uttered a cry of joy.

"Of course. I had not thought of that."

The next day she went to her friend's house and told her of her distress.

Madame Forestier went to her mirrored wardrobe, took out a large box, brought it back, opened it, and said to Madame Loisel:

"Choose, my dear."

First she saw some bracelets, then a pearl necklace, then a gold Venetian cross set with precious stones, of exquisite craftsmanship. She tried on the jewelry in the mirror, hesitated, could not bear to part with them, to give them back. She kept asking:

"You have nothing else?"

"Why, yes. But I don't know what you like."

Suddenly she discovered, in a black satin box, a superb diamond necklace, and her heart began to beat with uncontrolled desire. Her hands trembled as she took it. She fastened it around her neck, over her high-necked dress, and stood lost in ecstasy as she looked at herself.

Then she asked anxiously, hesitating:

"Would you lend me this, just this?"

"Why, yes, of course."

She threw her arms around her friend's neck, embraced her rapturously, then fled with her treasure.

The day of the party arrived. Madame Loisel was a success. She was prettier than all the other women, elegant, gracious, smiling, and full of joy. All the men stared at her, asked her name, tried to be introduced. All the cabinet officials wanted to waltz with her. The minister noticed her.

She danced wildly, with passion, drunk on pleasure, forgetting everything in the triumph of her beauty, in the glory of her success, in a sort of cloud of happiness, made up of all this respect, all this admiration, all these awakened desires, of that sense of triumph that is so sweet to a woman's heart.

She left at about four o'clock in the morning. Her husband had been dozing since midnight in a little deserted anteroom with three other gentlemen whose wives were having a good time.

He threw over her shoulders the clothes he had brought for her to go outside in, the modest clothes of an ordinary life, whose poverty contrasted sharply with the elegance of the ball dress. She felt this and wanted to run away, so she wouldn't be noticed by the other women who were wrapping themselves in expensive furs.

Loisel held her back.

"Wait a moment, you'll catch a cold outside. I'll go and find a cab."

But she would not listen to him, and ran down the stairs. When they were finally in the street, they could not find a cab, and began to look for one, shouting at the cabmen they saw passing in the distance.

They walked down toward the Seine in despair, shivering with cold. At last they found on the quay one of those old night cabs that one sees in Paris only after dark, as if they were ashamed to show their shabbiness during the day.

They were dropped off at their door in the Rue des Martyrs, and sadly walked up the steps to their apartment. It was all over, for her. And he was remembering that he had to be back at his office at ten o'clock.

In front of the mirror, she took off the clothes around her shoulders, taking a final look at herself in all her glory. But suddenly she uttered a cry. She no longer had the necklace round her neck!

"What is the matter?" asked her husband, already half undressed.

She turned towards him, panic-stricken.

"I have ... I have ... I no longer have Madame Forestier's necklace."

He stood up, distraught.

"What! ... how! ... That's impossible!"

They looked in the folds of her dress, in the folds of her cloak, in her pockets, everywhere. But they could not find it.

"Are you sure you still had it on when you left the ball?" he asked.

"Yes. I touched it in the hall at the Ministry."

"But if you had lost it in the street we would have heard it fall. It must be in the cab."

"Yes. That's probably it. Did you take his number?"

"No. And you, didn't you notice it?"

"No."

They stared at each other, stunned. At last Loisel put his clothes on again.

"I'm going back," he said, "over the whole route we walked, see if I can find it."

He left. She remained in her ball dress all evening, without the strength to go to bed, sitting on a chair, with no fire, her mind blank.

Her husband returned at about seven o'clock. He had found nothing.

He went to the police, to the newspapers to offer a reward, to the cab companies, everywhere the tiniest glimmer of hope led him.

She waited all day, in the same state of blank despair from before this frightful disaster.

Loisel returned in the evening, a hollow, pale figure; he had found nothing.

"You must write to your friend," he said, "tell her you have broken the clasp of her necklace and that you are having it mended. It will give us time to look some more."

She wrote as he dictated.

At the end of one week they had lost all hope.

And Loisel, who had aged five years, declared:

"We must consider how to replace the jewel."

The next day they took the box which had held it, and went to the jeweler whose name they found inside. He consulted his books.

"It was not I, madame, who sold the necklace; I must simply have supplied the case."

And so they went from jeweler to jeweler, looking for an necklace like the other one, consulting their memories, both sick with grief and anguish.

In a shop at the Palais Royal, they found a string of diamonds which seemed to be exactly what they were looking for. It was worth forty thousand *francs*. They could have it for thirty-six thousand.

So they begged the jeweler not to sell it for three days. And they made an arrangement that he would take it back for thirty-four thousand *francs* if the other necklace was found before the end of February.

Loisel had eighteen thousand *francs* which his father had left him. He would borrow the rest.

And he did borrow, asking for a thousand *francs* from one man, five hundred from another, five louis here, three louis there. He gave notes, made ruinous agreements, dealt with usurers, with every type of money-lender. He compromised the rest of his life, risked signing notes without knowing if he could ever honor them, and, terrified by the anguish still to come, by the black misery about to fall on him, by the prospect of every physical privation and every moral torture he was about to suffer, he went to get the new necklace, and laid down on the jeweler's counter thirty-six thousand *francs*.

When Madame Loisel took the necklace back, Madame Forestier said coldly:

"You should have returned it sooner, I might have needed it."

To the relief of her friend, she did not open the case. If she had detected the substitution, what would she have thought? What would she have said? Would she have taken her friend for a thief?

From then on, Madame Loisel knew the horrible life of the very poor. But she played her part heroically. The dreadful debt must be paid. She would pay it. They dismissed their maid; they changed their lodgings; they rented a garret under the roof.

She came to know the drudgery of housework, the odious labors of the kitchen. She washed the dishes, staining her rosy nails on greasy pots and the bottoms of pans. She washed the dirty linen, the shirts and the dishcloths, which she hung to dry on a line; she carried the garbage down to the street every morning, and carried up the water, stopping at each landing to catch her breath. And, dressed like a commoner, she went to the fruiterer's, the grocer's, the butcher's, her basket on her arm, bargaining, insulted, fighting over every miserable *sou*.

Each month they had to pay some notes, renew others, get more time.

Her husband worked every evening, doing accounts for a tradesman, and often, late into the night, he sat copying a manuscript at five *sous* a page.

And this life lasted ten years.

At the end of ten years they had paid off everything, everything, at usurer's rates and with the accumulations of compound interest.

Madame Loisel looked old now. She had become strong, hard and rough like all women of impoverished households. With hair half combed, with skirts awry, and reddened hands, she talked loudly as she washed the floor with great swishes of water. But sometimes, when her husband was at the office, she sat down near the window and thought of that evening at the ball so long ago, when she had been so beautiful and so admired.

What would have happened if she had not lost that necklace? Who knows, who knows? How strange life is, how fickle! How little is needed for one to be ruined or saved!

One Sunday, as she was walking in the Champs Élysées to refresh herself after the week's work, suddenly she saw a woman walking with a child. It was Madame Forestier, still young, still beautiful, still charming.

Madame Loisel felt emotional. Should she speak to her? Yes, of course. And now that she had paid, she would tell her all. Why not?

She went up to her.

"Good morning, Jeanne."

The other, astonished to be addressed so familiarly by this common woman, did not recognize her. She stammered:

"But - madame - I don't know. You must have made a mistake."

"No, I am Mathilde Loisel."

Her friend uttered a cry.

"Oh! ... my poor Mathilde, how you've changed! ..."

"Yes, I have had some hard times since I last saw you, and many miseries ... and all because of you! ..."

"Me? How can that be?"

"You remember that diamond necklace that you lent me to wear to the Ministry party?"

"Yes. Well?"

"Well, I lost it."

"What do you mean? You brought it back."

"I brought you back another exactly like it. And it has taken us ten years to pay for it. It wasn't easy for us, we had very little. But at last it is over, and I am very glad."

Madame Forestier was stunned.

"You say that you bought a diamond necklace to replace mine?"

"Yes; you didn't notice then? They were very similar."

And she smiled with proud and innocent pleasure.

Madame Forestier, deeply moved, took both her hands.

"Oh, my poor Mathilde! Mine was an imitation! It was worth five hundred *francs* at most! ..

Short Questions & Answers:

Question 1. How did the Loiseles react when they realised that the necklace had been lost?

Answer: Matilda Loisel became very sad when they realised that the necklace had been lost. They were sure that the loss of necklace would make their life hell because Mr Loisel was only a petty clerk and it was very difficult for him to replace necklace of diamond.

Question 2. Why did Matilda not like to visit her rich friend?

Answer: Matilda had inferiority complex. Whenever she visited her rich friend she felt dejected and disappointed because of her poverty. She used to compare her lodgings to that of her friend's. She did not have attractive dress and jewellery to adorn herself with. That is why, she did not like to visit her rich friend.

Question 3. Why is Matilda unhappy with her life?

Answer: Matilda is unhappy with her life because she ceaselessly, felt herself born for all delicacies and luxuries. The shabby walls, the worn chairs in her house tortured and angered her.

Question 4. Her husband is kind and loving. Do you agree? Give examples to support your answers.

Answer: He wants her to be happy. He spends a huge savings that he had saved for years to buy a gun for his hobby for buying a pretty dress for his wife so that she could attend a big party and enjoy it. When the costly necklace is lost, he spends all his savings and even borrow to repay it. He works day and night but never creates any ruckus with his wife.

Question 5. What had Matilda's husband saved the money for? Why did he then part with his savings?

Answer: Matilda's husband had saved a good amount of money to buy a gun for him. But when his wife refused to attend the party without a new dress, he had to give up buying the gun. He used the saved four hundred francs to buy her costume.

Question 6. What was the cause of Matilda's ruin? How could she have avoided it?

Answer: Matilda's aspiration and unrealistic dreams were the cause of her ruin. She paid due importance to materialistic things. She could have easily avoided if she had remained within her means. She was not a practical lady and had not understood her husband's feelings.

Long Questions & Answers:

Question 1. A little confession would have changed the life of Matilda. Should we confess our mistakes courageously? Do you agree about above statement?

Answer: Yes, a small mistake makes our life miserable and dark. People who are open-minded and speak the truth stay much happier. A little mistake made by Matilda changed her life completely. If Matilda had confessed that she had lost Madam Forestier's necklace, her life would have been different. Confession could have brought peace of mind. Matilda would have at once come to know that necklace is not a real but it is an imitation. Hard work which Matilda put into repay the borrowed necklace could have been saved. We all get a very important message that we should not delay in admitting our mistake.

Question 2. On inability to accept our circumstances may lead to an unhappy life. Explain with reference to the story "The Necklace".

Answer: We fail to recognise the situation in which we are placed but rather keep on grumbling. We become frustrated and want our life to be different. We should accept the life as it comes to us and should not keep on cribbing about unhappy circumstances. As we read the story 'The Necklace' we find that

Matilda is not at all happy with her husband. She had wished her life to be luxurious. It is this frustration of hers which puts her in a fix and spoils rest of her life. She does not work for solution but rather complicates the situation for her.

Question 3. 'Love is blind' is a phrase that was justified by Monsieur Loisel in the lesson 'The Necklace'. Substantiate the answer from the story you have read in about 100 – 120 words.

Answer: Monsieur Loisel's acceptance and contentment differ considerably from Matilda's emotional outbursts and constant dissatisfaction, and though he never fully understands his wife, he does his best to please her. When Monsieur Loisel tries to appease Matilda, he does it so blindly, wanting only to make her happy. When she declares that she cannot attend the party because she has nothing to wear, he gives her money to purchase a dress. When she complains that she has no proper jewelry, he urges her to visit Madame Forestier to borrow some.

Monsieur Loisel's eagerness and willingness to please Matilda becomes his downfall when she loses the necklace. He is the one who devises a plan for purchasing a replacement necklace and orchestrates the loans and mortgages that help them pay for it. Although the decision costs him ten years of hard work, he does not complain or imagine an alternate fate. It is as if his desires do not even exist or, at the very least, his desires are meaningless if they stand in the way of Matilda's.

Question 4. 'The Necklace' reveals that vanity is an evil. It may bring joy for short period but ultimately it leads to ruin. If you are placed in a situation similar to that of Matilda, what would you have done? Express your views.

Answer: No doubt, Matilda was proud and self-loving. She was very beautiful and charming and she was proud of her beauty. Because of her beauty, she thought that she was born in a family of clerks through the error of destiny. She felt that she was born for all delicacies and luxuries. She also felt that she was made for expensive frocks, jewels and other such things.

Therefore, we can conclude that Matilda was very vain and proud because of her beauty. When we read the story, we find out that she suffered because of her vanity. If I were placed in a situation similar to that of Matilda, I would have valued the love of my husband. I would have not insisted on buying an expensive dress to wear to the party. There would be no question of borrowing an expensive necklace from my friend. I would have saved me and my husband from all hardships which the Loisels went through.